# Jeffrey Cheng

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## Education

**Princeton University** **Aug 2025 - Present**
*PhD - Computer Science*

**Johns Hopkins University** **Aug 2023 - Dec 2024**
*MS - Computer Science* *GPA: 3.85*

**Duke University** **Aug 2019 - May 2023**
*BS - Mathematics, Distinction; Computer Science* *GPA: 3.90*

## Experience

**Princeton University** **Aug 2025 - Present**
*PhD Student advised by Danqi Chen* *Princeton, NJ*
- Research towards PhD: designed a pipeline to train a 4B chess-language model to play at Grandmaster strength and explain its reasoning in natural language [1]

**Microsoft Research** **Jan 2026 - Present**
*AI Research Engineer* *Remote*
- Research on retrieval systems and user personalization for Copilot Tuning Team.

**Johns Hopkins University** **Aug 2023 - May 2025**
*Research Assistant under Benjamin Van Durme* *Baltimore, MD*
- Foundation model research: identified mismatchs between reported and true knowledge cutoffs in open source models [5]; performed pioneering research in latent reasoning [4] and selective question answering [3]

**Duke University** **May 2022 - May 2023**
*Research Assistant under Tarek Elgindi* *Durham, NC*
- Fluid dynamics research on mixing and enhanced dissipation [6]

**IBM** **May 2022 - Aug. 2022**
*Software Developer Intern* *Chapel Hill, NC*

## Publications

[1] A. Bhaskar*, **J. Cheng***, D. Chen, Language Models that Play Chess and Explain Their Moves, *preprint*, 2026.

[2] J. Ou, W. Walden, K. Sanders, Z. Jiang, K. Sun, **J. Cheng**, W. Jurayj, M. Wanner, S. Liang, C. Morgan, S. Han, W. Wang, C. May, H. Recknor, D. Khashabi, B. Van Durme, ClaimCheck: How Grounded are LLM Critiques of Scientific Papers?, *in EMNLP Findings*, 2025

[3] W. Jurayj, **J. Cheng**, B. Van Durme, Is That Your Final Answer? Test-Time Scaling Improves Selective Question Answering, in *ACL*, 2025.

[4] **J. Cheng** & B. Van Durme, Compressed Chain of Thought: Efficient and Adaptive Reasoning through Dense Representations, *preprint*, 2024.

[5] **J. Cheng**, M. Marone, O. Weller, D. Lawrie, D. Khashabi, B. Van Durme, Dated Data: Tracing Knowledge Cutoffs in Large Language Models, in *COLM*, 2024. **Outstanding Paper Award (0.4%)**

[6] **J. Cheng** & T. Elgindi, Mixing and Enhanced Dissipation in Measure Preserving Dynamical Systems. Honors thesis, Duke University, 2023.

## Awards

**Francis Upton Fellowship, Princeton University** **Aug, 2025**
**Rubenstein Fellowship, Johns Hopkins University** **Aug, 2023**

## Teaching

**Graduate TA at Princeton University** **Fall 2026**
*Introduction to Machine Learning: COS324*

**Graduate TA at Johns Hopkins University** **Fall 2024**
*Natural Language Processing: CS671*

**Undergraduate TA at Duke University** **Fall 2022**
*Topology: MATH411*

**Undergraduate TA at Duke University** **Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Spring 2023**
*Design and Analysis of Algorithms: CS330*